

Land a flat in Germany without the German

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Bottom line up front

Non-fluent, newly-arrived renters lose flats they can afford — because they look risky on paper and can't produce a credible German application fast enough. In a market where one flat draws dozens of applicants, today's tools only store documents or buy visibility; none turn an expat's raw facts into a persuasive, personalised, fluent-German Bewerbung. The opportunity — BEST SHOT — is to give this underdog the best possible chance: assemble a landlord-ready application in credible German, safely and in their control, so they win the yes rather than merely clear the bar. We enter through a narrow beachhead — the non-fluent renter mid-application — and prove that a stronger application lifts reply rates.

Why the customer cares

The opportunity

BEST SHOT. A renter who has just moved to Germany is motivated to secure a home fast, but can't produce a credible, fluent-German application and doesn't even know what a "complete" one looks like — all while racing a stacked market. What they wish were true is simple: put their strongest foot forward and actually win. Problem + desire = the opportunity: help them land the flat, not just file the paperwork.

Cohorts

We design for one specific person, sliced by the moment they arrive:

- **Target customer** — a renter not fluent in German (e.g. an expat who just moved), applying in a stacked, fast-moving market where they start out the underdog.
- **Cohort A, cold start** — no flat yet; wants a generic Bewerbung ready to go.
- **Cohort B, mid-flow** — has found a specific flat and wants it tailored, fast. Proposed MVP wedge: highest intent, most urgent.

Empathy evidence

In the moment of applying the renter is **rushed and anxious** — already mid-application with the clock ticking — and has no patience for a tutorial.

Potential customer: "Just tell me what I need — don't lecture me."

A lived example from this session: the PM recently won a flat quickly by supplying the minimum the landlord asked for **and then some** — unprompted extras like liability insurance and professionally watermarked ID scans. Over-delivery, not mere compliance, won the yes.

Pains and gains

Pains (frustrations, anxieties, fears):

- **Miss the deadline** while assembling the pack; a faster applicant takes the flat.
- **A hidden, unwritten German rental norm** they never knew existed.
- **A required document missing** — found out too late.
- **Exposing sensitive data** (passport scans) with no easy way to protect it.
- **Silent screening** on name / nationality / language — evidenced (DeZIM: 22% vs 16% viewing invites; a Federal Court ruling).
- **The SCHUFA / no-German-credit wall** — can't be generated from abroad, yet treated as mandatory.

Gains (wants, needs, measures of success):

- **Provide data once, use it everywhere** — never re-enter your life story per flat.
- **Each application personalised to the landlord** — relevance lifts reply rates.
- **Go beyond the minimum** — present the strongest possible case.
- **Feel like the front-runner, not the underdog** — the emotional core the product must deliver.

Why the business cares

Context: there is no business yet. This is a portfolio MVP (built solo with an AI PM sparring partner), shipped on GitHub and mapped back to the opportunity — so “why the business cares” is really the strategy behind that.

Beachhead strategy. Win a deliberately narrow first market outright: small enough to dominate with an MVP, painful enough that users adopt eagerly and forgive rough edges, and a base to iterate from into adjacent use cases toward the broader mission of helping people find flats. The non-fluent renter is exactly that beachhead — an underdog with an acute, monetisable problem.

- **Willingness to pay is proven** — the only end-to-end “best shot” today is a €800-1,600 human relocation agent.
- **Reach** — a large, recurring expat inflow into German cities.

Not yet covered — market sizing (TAM / reach). Needed to judge how big the beachhead is and the expansion runway beyond it.

Competitor analysis — solutions today

Alternative	What it does	Strength	Gap it leaves
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Listing portals — ImmoScout24 Plus, WG-Gesucht+	Paid applicant profile + document locker (~€13-30/mo)	Own finding; boost visibility	No persuasive or fluent-German writing
Templates + credit / deposit tools — Selbstauskunft templates, SCHUFA / bonify, Getmomo	Supply individual pieces of the pack	Cheap, widely used	Not assembled; not personalised
Comms — portal templates, bulk-apply bots, settlyo, DeepL	Canned messages, volume applying, one-shot cover letters, translation	Fast / free	Generic or ToS-risky; translation ≠ credible German
Human relocation agents — BerlinRelo, FARAWAYHOME	End-to-end “best shot” service	Actually solves it	€800-1,600 — priced out for solo renters

White space. Nothing turns an expat’s raw facts into a credible, personalised, fluent-German Bewerbung. CREATE is the least-served job — and the most defensible place to enter.

The opportunity

Tied to the customer. The job is to land a flat in Germany without the German. BEST SHOT reframes it from compliance (“assemble the required documents”) to winning (“present the strongest, most credible case for this flat”). Why now: the pain is acute and the screening bias is structural; incumbents leave the CREATE job unserved; and fluent-German generation is newly feasible with modern AI — so a small tool can produce what previously took a €1,000+ agent.

Not yet covered — market sizing (GMV / TAM). Not covered this iteration.

How might we — mapped to the opportunity

How might we...	Maps back to (canvas)
Assemble a complete, landlord-ready Bewerbung fast — with no tutorial?	Pains: just-in-time guidance, missing doc, deadline
Let them enter their details once and reuse across every application?	Desire: data once, use everywhere
Make each application feel personal to that landlord, to lift reply rates?	Desire: personalised; Pain: silent screening
Go beyond the minimum with proactive reassurance?	Desire: beyond the minimum

Protect their sensitive data by default (e.g. auto-watermark)?	Pain: exposing passport data
Coach them past the SCHUFA / no-credit wall with credible substitutes?	Evidence: SCHUFA wall

How might we — prioritised (MoSCoW)

The team prioritised with MoSCoW over a pure stack-rank: for an MVP some things are non-negotiable. Criteria map to the canvas — **Must** = lawful and advances the customer opportunity + business mission; **Should** = advances the opportunity + mission; **Could** = maps to a pain but not essential to what we're testing; **Won't (yet)** = consciously parked.

Priority	How might we...	Why here
MUST	Assemble a complete, landlord-ready Bewerbung fast	The core CREATE job — the white space itself
MUST	Handle their data safely & lawfully (e.g. auto-watermark IDs)	A legal / compliance floor, not a feature
SHOULD	Make it read as credible, fluent German	The differentiator vs. a doc-locker (proposed split from “personalise”)
SHOULD	Tailor each application to the specific landlord	Lifts reply rates; personalisation as polish
SHOULD	Enter details once, reuse across every application	High-leverage enabler for applying at scale
COULD	Nudge them to go beyond the minimum (reassurance)	Differentiator from the win-story; cheap to add
WON'T (yet)	Coach past the SCHUFA / no-credit wall	Thorny, partly served elsewhere; consciously parked

Open gaps & assumptions to resolve

Riskiest assumption. Does a credible, fluent-German, personalised application actually lift reply rates for a foreign-name applicant? Structural bias (DeZIM 22% vs 16%) means a better application improves the odds but cannot guarantee the flat. Worth a cheap test before heavy build.

- **Success metric** — measure reply / viewing-invite rate, not “got the flat”, or a working product will be under-credited.
- **MVP cohort** — Cohort B (mid-flow) proposed as the wedge, not yet ratified.
- **Personalisation split** — “fluent-German credibility” (Must) vs “per-landlord tailoring” (Should) is a proposed sharpening; the canvas still lists a single Should.
- **Market sizing** — TAM / reach not sized this iteration.

Sources: three research fact-packs in the research/ folder in this case study (Bewerbermappe checklist; expat renter pains, incl. DeZIM 22% vs 16% and a Federal Court ruling; Berlin solutions-today). Live canvas: Miro — “Opportunity Canvas: Land a flat in Germany without the German”.